

Objective

Students analyze a real case file, identify the different types of evidence, evaluate which are strongest, and debate how they would be used in court.

Case File Handout – Boston Marathon Bombing (Simplified) Scenario (April 15, 2013)

Two homemade bombs exploded near the finish line of the Boston Marathon, killing 3 people and injuring hundreds. Investigators collected different types of evidence to identify and prosecute the suspects, Tamerlan and Dzhokhar Tsarnaev.

Setup

Prepare 4–5 Ziploc bags (one per table/group).

Each bag contains mock evidence items (printed, crafted, or found) representing different evidence types from the Boston Marathon case.

Each item should have a short description or label attached (so students know what it represents).

Bag Contents (Sample Evidence Items)

Physical Evidence

A piece of metal scrap (3D printed) → labeled “Fragment from pressure cooker bomb.”

A backpack strap (piece of material) → labeled “Recovered near blast site.”

Biological Evidence

Cotton swab in a small plastic bag → labeled “DNA trace from backpack strap – matches Dzhokhar Tsarnaev.”

Digital Evidence

Printed still image from blurry security footage (laser engraved on a piece of wood) → labeled “Security camera shows suspect placing backpack at 11:47 PM.”

Fake text message (3D printed phone, sublimation printing for messages) → “We’re going to hit them hard today.”

Testimonial Evidence

Index card with a quote → “Witness saw a young man drop a backpack near the finish line minutes before the explosion.”

Documentary Evidence

Fake store receipt (printout) → “Receipt for pressure cooker purchased 2 weeks earlier.”

Instructions to Students

Open the “evidence bag” and examine each item.

As a group, discuss:

- Which pieces are strongest and most reliable?
- Which are weak or questionable?
- If you were the prosecution, which 2–3 would you highlight?
- If you were the defense, which would you attack?
- Prepare to share your group’s decisions with the class.

Timing

Intro (3 min): Explain types of evidence.

Activity (8 min): Groups go through their evidence bag and make decisions.

Debrief (4–5 min): Groups share their strongest and weakest evidence picks.

Wrap-up (2–3 min): Connect to real trial outcomes and importance of multiple evidence types.

Instructions:

1. Refer to the evidence log below and examine the evidence provided
2. As a group, please discuss:
 - Which piece of evidence do you believe is strongest and most reliable?
 - Which pieces of evidence would you consider weak or questionable?
 - If you were the prosecution, which 2–3 pieces of evidence would you highlight?
 - If you were the defense, which piece of evidence would you challenge?
3. Prepare to share your group's decisions with the class.

Evidence Log		
Date of Incident: April 15th, 2013		
Case: Boston Marathon Bombing		
Evidence No.	Item	Description of Evidence Collected
1	Metal Shrapnel	Fragment from pressure cooker bomb
2	Cotton Swab	DNA trace from backpack found at the scene of the crime - matches Dzhokhar Tsarnaev.
3	Security Camera Footage	Security camera footage shows both suspects in the area prior to the explosion wearing backpacks.
4	Text Message	Sent by Suspect 1, received by Suspect 2, on the morning of April 15th, 2013.
5	Index Card	Statement of witness testimony.
6	Receipt	Receipt showing the purchase of tools used in the crime 2 weeks prior to the event.